

ENGLISH LANGUAGE PAPER 4

PART A Group Interaction

This article appeared in a magazine:

How phobias happen, and what you can do if you have an irrational fear

Have you heard of *Chelonaphobia*, or fear of turtles? Emily Ko, a Hong Kong-born freelance writer is scared of turtles, and while it sounds silly to most people, that's exactly what a phobia is – an extreme fear of a threat and expecting danger that's out of proportion to the actual risk.

"I was five years old when my parents came home with two pet turtles," Emily says. "I freaked out. Obviously, my parents didn't throw away the turtles – they put them in my brother's room. But these things live long lives... I didn't go into that bedroom for 10 years."

Hong Kong-based hypnotherapist Sonia Samtani has dealt with a range of phobias – some common, some not. "I've treated people for fear of public speaking, cockroaches, needles, medical procedures, flying and dark spaces, and less common phobias such as cats, escalators, and pigeons." Samtani says phobias can also eat away at a person's self-confidence and self-esteem. The impact may get more severe if that person doesn't know why they are scared of something.

However, there are techniques that can help people overcome even the most extreme phobias. One popular type of treatment that helps people change the way they think and behave, is to gradually expose them to their fear so they feel less anxious about it. In this way, people don't have to suffer from phobias all their lives.

Your group is doing a group project about common fears among Hong Kong teenagers. You may want to talk about:

- common fears that Hong Kong teenagers have
- why they may have such fears
- how they can overcome those fears
- anything else you think is important

PART B Individual Response

1. What things are you afraid of?
2. Do you know anybody who is scared of an animal?
3. Were you afraid of anything when you were younger?
4. Why would some people be afraid of taking the lift?
5. How can you help a friend who has a fear of public speaking?
6. Where would you seek help if you had a fear of something?
7. How do people's fears affect their self-confidence?
8. Do you think some fears might disappear as you get older?